



Reviving employees' essence of hospitality through spiritual wellbeing, spiritual leadership, and emotional intelligence

Steven W. Bayighomog^{a,*}, Hüseyin Arasli^b

^a Department of Business Administration, Cyprus International University, Nicosia, North Cyprus, Via Mersin 10, Turkey

^b Norwegian School of Hotel Management, University of Stavanger, Stavanger, Norway

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ABSTRACT

This study contributes to the ongoing discussion stressing the need to reinvigorate meaning and purpose to the younger generation of employees and revitalize the essence of hospitality. To this end, the study proposes and tests a model of how spiritual leadership and emotional intelligence are related, directly and indirectly through spiritual wellbeing, to the creative performance and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (COBSB) of employees. The research hypotheses were tested using data collected from 238 frontline hotel employees and 53 supervisors and analyzed via nonlinear estimations. The findings revealed that spiritual leadership and emotional intelligence were curvilinearly related to spiritual wellbeing, COBSB, and creative performance. Specifically, too much of spiritual leadership was not necessarily a good thing, and the less emotionally intelligent can sometimes be better off. Moreover, spiritual wellbeing mediated the relationship of emotional intelligence and spiritual leadership with COBSB and creative performance. Implications for theory and practice are discussed further.

1. Introduction

The scholarship of employee occupational wellbeing in the hospitality industry has surged in recent years (Uysal et al., 2020). Of particular interest were indicators of negative wellbeing such as stress and burnout (e.g., Anasori et al., 2020; Jung & Yoon, 2016a) and hedonic wellbeing such as satisfaction and quality of [work] life (e.g., Kara et al., 2018). The stress on these dimensions of wellbeing is not surprising, considering the challenges associated with hospitality jobs such as long/odd working hours, low pay, pressure, emotional labor. However, underwhelming attention has been dedicated to hospitality employees' eudaimonic wellbeing, the other positive psychological form of wellbeing associated with learning, personal growth, thriving and meaning (Inceoglu et al., 2018; Jung & Yoon, 2016b).

This is rather surprising given that hospitality scholars have stressed that a sense of meaning in work is substantially lacking among younger generations of employees such as the Millennials who tend to work to live instead of living to work as opposed to the Baby Boomers (Golubovskaya et al., 2017; Gursoy et al., 2013). This in turn makes them vulnerable to psychological problems as a result of loneliness, depression, and burnout, which are the foremost reasons for job resignation of nearly 50 % of Millennials and 75 % of Generation Zers (Gursoy et al.,

2013; Mind Share Partners, 2019). Adding this to the grueling nature of hospitality jobs, it becomes less surprising to see why the younger employees are prey to declining psychological (and physiological) wellbeing, sense of meaning, and purpose. These are pivotal for hospitality employees because it drives their internal motives, enthusiasm, and ultimately desirable outcomes (Hunsaker, 2020; Jung & Yoon, 2016b).

Accordingly, our study emphasizes spiritual wellbeing (SWB) which encompasses orthodox views of subjective, psychological, and social wellbeing that consider wellbeing as purpose, meaning, quality of life, interrelationships, connectedness, happiness (Hunsaker, 2020; Nicolaides, 2018). Employees with SWB experience transcendence, perceive the significance of their work, and feel a sense of interconnectedness and community at work, through calling and membership (Fry, 2003; Nicolaides, 2018). This study emphasizes SWB as a form of eudaimonic wellbeing, which studies have reported being robustly associated with, and particularly significant for maximizing and sustaining overall wellbeing than hedonic wellbeing (Di Fabio & Kenny, 2016, 2019). We develop and test a framework around SWB, that extends management and organization research, and the hospitality and tourism body of knowledge in several ways.

First, this study responds to the call of Inceoglu et al. (2018) who underscores the limited scholarly attention on a comprehensive range of

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: sbayig@ciu.edu.tr (S.W. Bayighomog), araslih@gmail.com (H. Arasli).